

Communications Committee Report to the Annual General Meeting of the
Thetis Island Residents' and Ratepayers' Association
March 24, 2024

This year has had a number of challenges in communications. The webcam is a very old system, and at first, the challenge was to help people to adjust their various browser settings to show the images, because newer browsers kept hanging onto the old images. But now there's a new and probably terminal problem, that our new web host's system is too new for the camera, and they can't find a way to make the transmission work. Sony Falardeau at Capernwray has been a prince among men for working to find ways around the problem, and he may yet find one, but he is also looking for a new camera that will work for us. Mass market web cameras are geared to security needs, which have a totally different way of communicating, needing a much more complex (and expensive) interface at our end. It's not just about the money, it's about the management once it's running. Capernwray is the most capable resource we have for the management, and they are not, at this point, comfortable with taking that on.

And speaking of web hosts, we changed to a Canadian company after the former host increased our annual cost dramatically, from \$60 to \$238 per year USD. This has now been done, although it took awhile to get the email forwarding set up properly again. Regarding the webcam issue (which was a surprise), even if we had stayed with the old web host, at 4 times the fee we were paying before, wouldn't have worked for long. They were raising their price so they could update their equipment. It was a case of "sooner or later".

Work on the phone book is ongoing - it's now in the production chute with the Visitors' Guide. I hope to get it done before the Guide has to be out, which is usually for the May long weekend. We are promised that the post office box question will be resolved soon, and hope that the book and the boxes will cooperate on timing.

Espokes continues to be an enormously popular and well-used communication vehicle, but it does have it's issues from time to time. It had to be transferred to a different mailing program because of new internet restrictions on bulk mailing. Matt and Claire Hess managed to achieve this and things seem to be working well. It was a complicated and frustrating job to make the change and we are extremely grateful to them. Claire and the team have also worked to clarify the Guidelines for posting with a new format and, hopefully, all issues included. These new Guidelines are available online at thetisland.net. Many thanks to Claire and the others on the team, Nancy Sinclair and Virginia Vitzthum, for faithfully maintaining this truly essential resource.

*Veronica Shelford, Chair
TIRRA Communications*